



LEADERS MUST BUILD CONSENSUS

Deep Saini, President and Vice-Chancellor of McGill University, on how B-schools can remain relevant and why providing value to society is important

BY SIDDHARTH ZARABI

52 | **DEEP SAINI**, President and Vice-Chancellor of McGill University, one of Canada's most prestigious institutions, was born and educated in India before pursuing an international academic career; he now leads a globally recognised research university and manages a budget of about \$2 billion. In a rapidly changing global environment, where technology, geopolitics and shifting student flows are reshaping higher learning, Saini argues that management education must evolve just as quickly. During a recent visit to India, he spoke with *BT* about how universities can stay relevant, how leadership models are being rewritten, and

why adaptability will define the next generation of managers. Edited excerpts:



Indian students face increasing barriers to their aspirations to study overseas. Do you see a permanent shift in how Indian students pursue education and opportunities, including in the US?

There is a wider global shift underway, not just in the US. My hope is that the current barriers are not permanent, but institutions must be prepared if they become so. Student mobility will continue; it may not remain at the levels of the last two decades, but no country can afford

isolation. There will be a correction to what we see in the US today, though not a return to the past—it will be something new, with new opportunities.

The real challenge for institutions is anticipating where this change is heading. As Wayne Gretzky (former Canadian ice hockey player) said, success comes from knowing where the puck will be, not where it is. At McGill, we are applying that philosophy. We have launched a major institutional review examining everything we do—teaching, operations, admissions—to decide what to continue, what to stop and what new ideas to adopt.

On mobility specifically, Canada remains

open. This year, each university received a quota for international students; McGill finished slightly below its quota because we deliberately control admissions. There is room for more high-achieving international students, including from India, to come to McGill and thrive globally, as our alumni already do in more than 185 countries.



McGill University's school of management dates back to 1906 and is among the first globally. How do you see the role of modern business education, given that corporations have to keep playing catch-up with so much change, including technology?